208/1
LITERATURE IN ENGLISH
Paper 1
July/August 2026
2 hours

WAKISSHA JOINT MOCK EXAMINATIONS

Uganda Certificate of Education

LITERATURE IN ENGLISH

Paper 1

2 hours

INSTRUCTIONS TO CANDIDATES:

This paper consists of *two Sections; A and B. It has three examination items.*

*Section A has **one compulsory** item.*

*There are two examination items in section **B**. Respond to **one item.***

*Respond to **two** items in all.*

Any additional item responded to will not be scored.

All responses must be written in the Answer Booklet(s)/sheets provided.

Turn Over

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SECTION A

ITEM 1

Read the text below and respond to the tasks after it.

"You say you have only four days to stay with us?"

"Yes," said Obi. "But I will do my best to come again within a year. I must be in Lagos to see about getting a job."

"Yes," said his father slowly. "A job is the first thing. A person who has not secured a place on the floor should not begin to look for a mat." After a pause he said: "There are many things to talk about, but not tonight. You are tired and need sleep."

"I am not very tired, Father. But perhaps it is better to talk tomorrow. There is one thing however, about which you should have a restful mind. There will be no question of John not finishing his course at the Grammar School."

"Good night, my son and God bless you."

"Good night, Father."

He borrowed the ancient hurricane lamp to see his way to his room and bed. There was a brand-new white sheet on the old wooden bed with its hard grass-filled mattress. The pillowslips, with their delicate floral designs were no doubt Esther's work. "Good old Esther!" Obi thought. He remembered when he was a little boy and Esther had just become a teacher. Everyone said that she should no longer be called Esther because it was disrespectful, but Miss. So she was called Miss. Sometimes Obi forgot and called her Esther, whereupon Charity told him how rude he was.

In those days, Obi got on very well with his three eldest sisters, Esther, Janet and Agnes, but not with Charity, who was his immediate elder. Charity's Ibo name was "A girl is also good," but whenever they quarrelled Obi called her "A girl is not good." Then, she would beat him until he cried unless their mother happened to be around, in which case Charity would postpone the beating. She was as strong as iron and was feared by other children in the neighborhood, even the boys.

Obi did not sleep for a long time after he had lain down. He thought about his responsibilities. It was clear that his parents could no longer stand on their own. They had never relied on his father's meager pension. He planted yams and his wife planted cassava and coco yams. She also made soap from leachings of palm ash and oil and sold it to villagers for a little profit. But now they were too old for these things.

"I must give them a monthly allowance from my salary." How much? Could he afford, ten pounds? If only he did not have to pay twenty pounds a month to the Umuofia Progressive Union. Then there was John's school fees.

"We'll manage somehow," he said aloud to himself. "One cannot have it both ways. There are many young men in this country today who would sacrifice themselves to get the opportunity I have had."

Outside, a strong wind had suddenly arisen and the disturbed trees became noisy. Flashes of lightning showed through the jalousie. It was going to rain. Obi liked rain at night. He forgot his responsibilities and thought about Clara, how heavenly it would be on such a night to feel her cool body against his—the shapely thighs and succulent breasts.

Why had she said he should not tell his parents about her yet? Could it be that her mind was still not made up? He would have liked to tell his mother at least. He knew she

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would be overjoyed. She once said she would be ready to depart when she had seen his first child. That was before he went to England; it must have been when Esther's first child was born. She now had three, Janet two, Agnes one. Agnes would have had two if her first child had lived. It must be dreadful to lose one's first child, especially for a little girl like Agnes; she was no more than a little girl really at the time she got married—in her behavior at least. Even now, she still had not quite grown up. Her mother always told her so. Obi smiled in the darkness as he remembered the little incident after prayers an hour or two ago.

Agnes had been asked to carry the little children, who were already asleep on the floor, to their beds.

"Wake them up to urinate first or they will do it in their beds," said Esther. Agnes grabbed the first child by the wrist and pulled him up.

"Agnes! Agnes!" screamed their mother, who was sitting on a low stool beside the sleeping children, "I have always said that your head is not correct. How often must I tell you to call a child by name before waking him up?"

"Don't you know," Obi took up pretending great anger, "that if you pull him up suddenly his soul may not be able to get back to his body before he wakes?"

The girls laughed. Obi had not changed a bit. He enjoyed teasing them, their mother not exempted. She smiled.

"You may laugh if laughter catches you," she said indulgently. "it does not catch me."

"That is why Father calls them the foolish virgins," said Obi.

It was now beginning to rain with thunder and lightning. At first large raindrops drummed on the iron roof. It was as though thousands of pebbles, each wrapped separately in a piece of cloth to break its fall, had been let loose from the sky. Obi wished that it was daytime so that he could see a tropical rain once more. It was now gathering strength. The drumming of large single drops gave way to a steady downpour.

"I had forgotten it could rain so heavily in November," he thought as he rearranged his loincloth to cover his whole body. Actually such rain was unusual. It was as though the deity presiding over the waters in the sky found, on checking his stock and counting off the months on his fingers, that there was too much rain left and that he had to do something drastic about it before the impending dry season.

Obi composed himself and went to sleep.

(Source: No Longer at Ease by Chinua Achebe)

Tasks:

(a) In every story in Literature, events take place in specific locations, time and sociocultural setting. Explain the setting of the passage.

(b) In literature, conflict develops around characters. The way they go about it determines their relationships, personality and role. Describe the relationship between Obi and his family in the text.

(c) The writer's style is important in helping him bring out the message to the intended audience effortlessly. Explain the narrative techniques used in the text.

(d) For literature to prove ageless, it must address such issues as they are in the contemporary society. *How relevant is the text to your community today?*

Turn Over

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SECTION B

Choose one task from this section. Illustrate your answer by referring to one of the set books below that you have studied.

FRANCIS IMBUGA:	*Betrayal in the city*
FRANCIS IMBUGA:	*Aminata*
SYLVESTER ONZIVUA:	*The Heartshooters*
NGUGI WA THIONG'O:	*Weep Not Child*
MEJA MWANGI:	*Carcase for Hounds*
CLIVE LEWIS:	*Rebel without a Gun*
D.WOOGLER & K. OGUNGBESAN:	*Rhymes and Rhythms*
RICHARD MWEBESA:	*Thistles of the Nile*
OXFORD UNIVERSITY PRESS:	*Counter point and other poems*

EITHER

Item 2

In literature, the relationships of characters, their challenges and successes become an inspiration to the readers. Some characters are admirable and others are not. Choose one of the set books above, identify an admirable character in it and explain why you think they are admirable.

OR

Item 3

Literature is valuable for the insights about life, humanity and the society that it gives readers. These insights are the themes and ideas. Choosing any of the texts above, discuss the theme it develops.

END

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